Metagaming, raiding, and scientific rigour – what does CivLabs do about it?

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Exclusive interviews with the IMS Publishing Department reveal what CivLabs players think of the civilisation server.

CivLabs is a Minecraft server which hosts events that encourage players to co-operate and work with each other, replicating a real civilisation. Through the server's own plugin, it forces players to "specialize in certain gameplay aspects", making players rely on each other.

Uniquely CivLabs: Metagaming

Metagaming, according to CivLab's FAQ page, is defined as the "act of sharing knowledge from the current Minecraft world(s) to other players". It claims that this ensures the integrity of the experiment as there would be a "natural flow of information" within the world.

This is something that oliver loves maps, a player who joined in July 2025, says is beneficial.

He says players aren't able to look for their pre-existing friends, making new relationships "naturally emergent" and "genuinely last". Further, he notes that this unique mechanic also affects how players discover new civilisations – it is much more difficult, he says, but much more rewarding at the same time.

He also says that you have to "listen for gossip and rumours" to know where civilisations are, unlike the typical server where information may be shared in a wiki or Discord server. He then has to go around asking what people know, having "no clue what to expect".

Civilisation experiments without metagaming restrictions, such as Ish's one-thousand-player events, make the server feel "much less serious" and are "never very fun to play" when comapred to CivLabs.

Should raiders be allowed?

Rubix, a player who joined in the early days of CivLabs during Trial 1 (10 August 2025), the first for collecting data, found the scientific rigour of the server made it especially unique.

He says that CivLabs has not taken action against raiders who have regularly caused havoc since Event 3, except when these players have explicitly broken rules. This issue has caused a "rift" among players, many of whom have "no interest at all" in PvP.

When the "loudest" anti-raider players started their own server called Era, Rubix thought the social interactions were very interesting but found the "LARP-y" interactions tedious. LARP, according to the CivLabs wiki, refers to "leisurely, inefficient or non-pragmatic" interactions.

Era was also focused more on roleplay and entertainment, something he rapidly became bored of. He says these things distract from "scientific rigor" and "experimentation".

Does CivLabs reflect real life beahviour?

Grevias, a player who joined in September 2025 and has previously led a civilisation, explains that despite the aim of scientific rigour and rules against metagaming, CivLabs “definitely” does not reflect the behaviour of people in real life.

She says everyday people do not throw their lives away to hurt other people with no gain, and that war is rare in real life. In contrast, nations can get “razed to dust”.

A way to mitigate this issue could be to have a “positive culture” where raiders are not as prevalent and players behave naturally. However, she says CivLabs is infested with raiders and pro-raiders, meaning this ideal culture is unlikely to happen.

Science or engagement?

Ultimately, CivLabs faces a difficult crossroads – does it stick with its scientific and experimental values and maintain a hands-off style of staff intervention? Or should it take the opportunity it has to shape the perfect server that blends the empirical nature of data collection for research, and also the hard-fought culture of systems built for player-to-player interactions?

As the veteran CivLabs players interviewed by the PubDep have said, this is still a contentious issue.

The IMS has previously debated the issue of anarchy and players who enjoy raiding builds on multiple occasions – with the introduction of CivLabs to the community, it could reignite this hot-button issue.